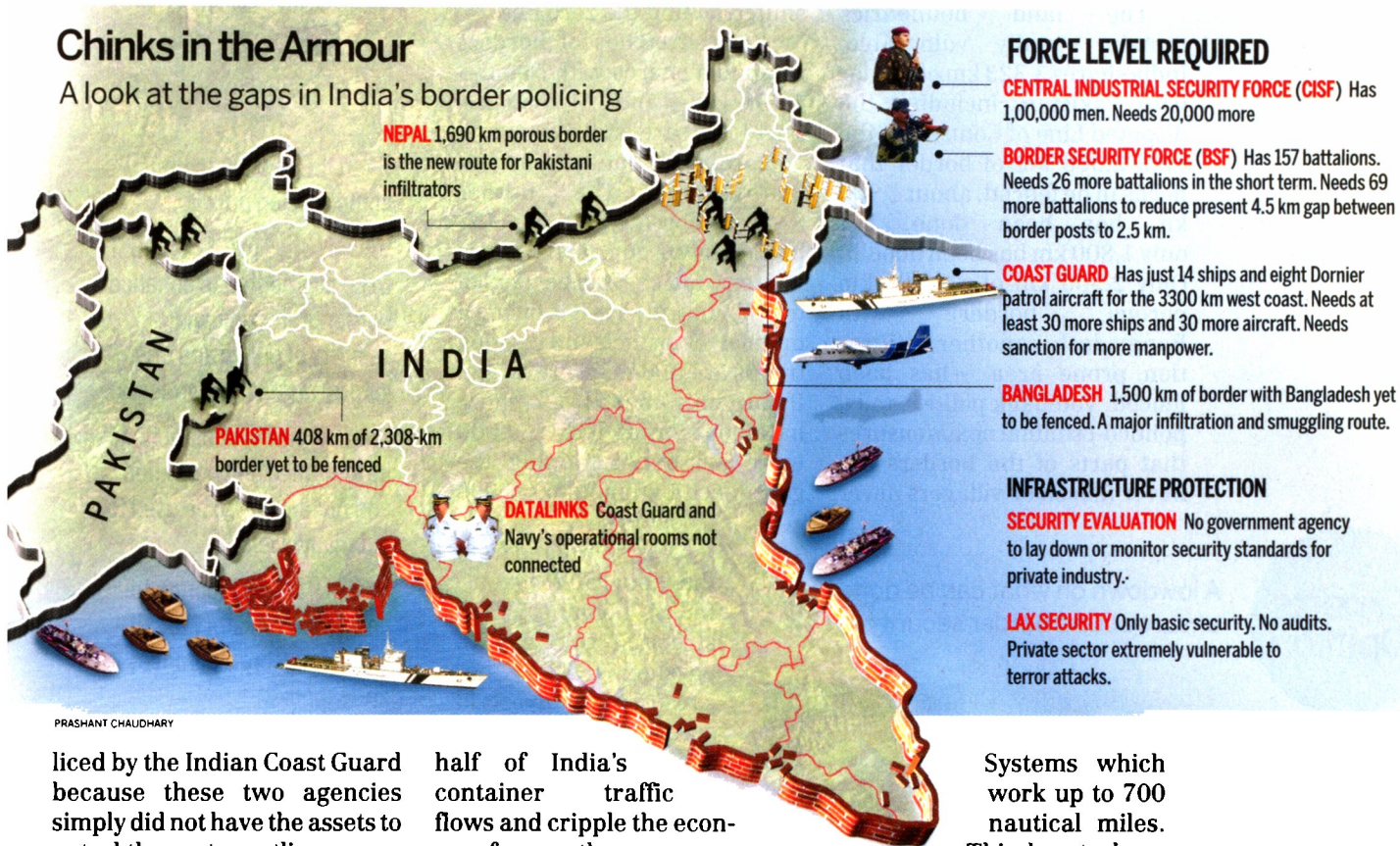


Chinks in the Armour

A look at the gaps in India's border policing



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liced by the Indian Coast Guard because these two agencies simply did not have the assets to patrol the vast coastline.

The marine police, a concept established after the 1993 Mumbai serial blasts where explosives were smuggled in through the sea, is yet to take off in the nine coastal states because state authorities are reluctant to invest resources in coastal policing. This despite the threat from the sea being enormous and multifarious. The spate of pirate attacks off the coast of Somalia have shown just how simple it is for a boat load of armed miscreants to hijack a ship the size of a supertanker. A single cargo ship with 40,000 tonnes of a fertiliser like ammonium nitrate has the potency of a 40 kiloton nuclear weapon or nearly twice the size of the bombs dropped on Hiroshima and Nagasaki. Blowing up a ship of this size at the Jawaharlal Nehru Port Trust (JNPT) could destroy the gateway through which over

half of India's container traffic flows and cripple the economy for months.

What is needed is a concept called Maritime Domain Awareness (MDA) which emerged in the US after the 9/11 attacks. The Department of Homeland Security knitted all organisations—customs, coast guard and immigration services—into a sensory web. The National Maritime Adviser and the planned coastal command must have such a system to ensure effective coordination of at least eight different ministries concerned with maritime affairs. Fishing vessels need to be upgraded with Automatic Identification System which work up to 100 nautical miles and Long Range Identification and Tracker

Systems which work up to 700 nautical miles. This has to happen with a simultaneous augmentation of the Coast Guard by at least four times of its present strength and personnel doubled. The Coast Guard which patrols Indian territorial waters from 12 nautical miles to 200 nautical miles has a fleet of just 74 ships, 44 aircraft and 8,000 men for the task. In sharp contrast, South Korea, a country the size of Chhattisgarh has double these ships in its coast guard. The Government should also consider re-employing most of the 5,000 experienced sailors who retire from the Indian Navy each year to fill up at least 10,000 personnel needed for the state marine police units.

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